

You said it...



Typically, whom would you call up or ask for support when any of these devices don't work as they should or as advertised in the absence of drivers? Is it the OS vendor Microsoft or the device manufacturers, ASUS and Epson? Would it not be the latter pair, rather than Microsoft? Similarly, calling Epson or ASUS for support would be more appropriate even with your Linux OS.

Linux, as of today, supports the most number of hardware devices out-of-the-box compared to Windows and other proprietary OSs. This is largely due to the occurrence of any of the following three scenarios:

1. The hardware manufacturer works with the Linux device driver developers—thus pushing its drivers to be included in the kernel, by default. For example, Linux is the first kernel to support USB3 specifications.
2. The hardware manufacturer makes the hardware specs of a device available—which enables the Linux device driver developers to write the required drivers.
3. The hardware manufacturer neither works with the Linux device driver developers, nor makes the device specs available—which forces the Linux developers to derive the driver software by reverse engineering.

There's one other mode of hardware support—the device manufacturer makes proprietary drivers easily available for different Linux distros to include, e.g., NVIDIA. This is arguably not the best of solutions (from the freedom point of view), but it works, nonetheless.

What's important to understand is the third scenario. Reverse engineering by guessing the specs of a device is not the easiest of jobs—yet many work at it just to make users' lives easier.

We, non-developers, could also help FOSS developers out—by asking the hardware vendors to support our OS. If they don't, then we should return their products saying that they don't work as advertised.

Better still, before buying a product, check if it works on Linux. Even when you know it works, still ask the sales team about it—they should know that Windows is not the only OS people use. And refuse to buy a product that doesn't support Linux.

It's small things like these that can help you, and all of us, out. Why? Because the moment the manufacturer realises that it's losing out on potential customers in the absence of Linux support, it has to rethink its strategy.

At the end of the day, manufacturers are rolling out products to make money by selling them. They support Windows only because they think that's their only market. We users need to make them realise that there are many people using Linux too. As long as we don't do our part, things won't change.

Hartmut replies: Following your suggestions I tried to

download the device drivers:

- ASUS, I just come to know, has no specific driver for any Linux system.
- Epson drivers are available and installed.

So, it is not a problem with any of the hardware drivers but with the handling of USB in the Linux system itself. Connecting, disconnecting or re-connecting at any of the USB jacks renders the entire USB system not to work, except for those units not disconnected or switched. Strange, isn't it?

Just check the loads of "usb-printer-problems" in the respective websites of all OS flavours and hardware brands—everywhere it's the same problem. The solutions recommended are as many as the questions. It is a Linux internal matter.

In a German website I found a question similar to mine, raised by a software(!) company. It was not able to solve the problem and switched back to MS because of the need to print.

Please find out what is wrong. I don't have the means to do this. Linux is using a lot of software made by 'outsiders', e.g., CUPS, which is an Apple product. It works with ghostwrite, foomatic, gutenprint It works, but who is going to standardise what is necessary?

You are right: we have to support and defend the freedom of our system. Salesmen want to sell—for them, 'everything' will work with Linux. Indeed, you will find a lot of 'workarounds' even for extreme hardware on the Internet. That shows the power of the Linux idea but also the ignorance of (at least some) people working for it. Sorry, for my openness but with Linux, it has to be so...

ED: *It's indeed strange that although you have the official Epson drivers, your printer still doesn't work. Here at EFY, we often connect HP printers using USB, to our systems, and they work fine. We would recommend you contact Epson, and also file a bug report about the problem in the bug tracking system of the distro(s) you're using.*

The FOSS ecosystem is a collaborative effort—that's why there are independent projects working on different software and applications. For example, CUPS has always been the print server software for Linux—Apple bought CUPS only in 2007. Anyway, we'd love to have the views of the community and our readers on the topic brought up by Hartmut. Thank you for your valuable feedback. Keep it coming!:-)

Please send your comments or suggestions to:

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